
FINAL LIGHT
QUICK START RULES
QUEST ADON

Six years ago, a blood-borne pathogen mutated the minds and bodies of humans, resulting in the loss of more than five billion lives over the course of a few months. The world went dark. Those who remained did what they had to just to survive another day in a world where their neighbours had become monsters.

Now a vaccine exists. 50% effectiveness. It's the difference between no hope and just enough.

You are not heroes. You are survivors who have lost more than you thought possible. You can only hope you're moving towards something worth reaching.

**FINAL LIGHT**

Game by Sarah Brown

Art by Camille Barbieri & Sarah Brown

*The full Final Light Core Book and adventures are available at questadon.com.*

# INTRODUCTION



Final Light is a cinematic survival horror tabletop roleplaying game for 2–4 players and a GM. You play ordinary people six years into a zombie apocalypse. No magic, no superhuman abilities—all you have is what you can find, craft, and carry. Through stealth, hard choices, and the moments between the running, each player will find out whether there's still a reason to keep going… if you do make it out alive.

**This quickstart is one night in that world:** a single three or four hour session with pre-made characters and a scenario that teaches you how to play. It's the whole system in miniature, setting you up for a full adventure if you end your night and wish it wasn't over.

**What Final Light isn't:** an open-world sandbox, a base-builder, or a dungeon crawl. There are great games for those.

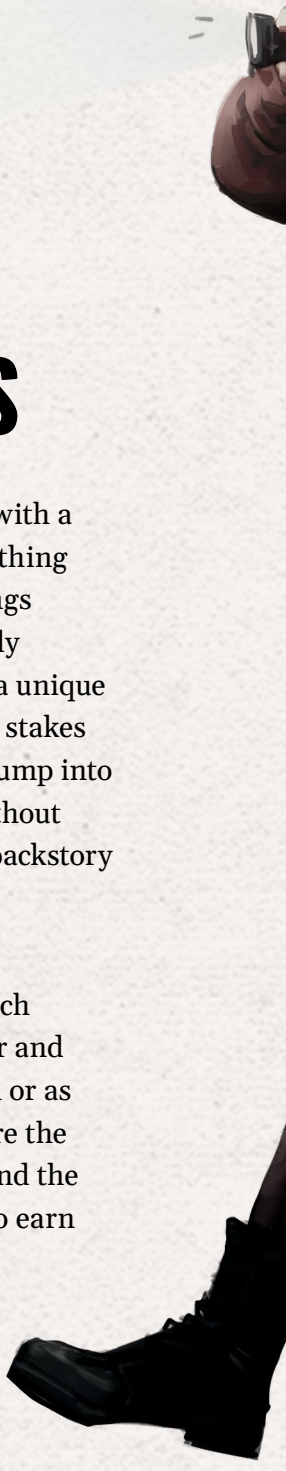
Final Light is played in short adventures that last 3–5 sessions and tell character-first, intense zombie stories. Some of the media that inspired me should make the tone of the game clear: games like *The Last of Us*, *Nemesis*, and *Alice Is Missing*, and movies like *28 Days Later* and *Train to Busan*. This is immersive roleplay with heart-pounding encounters where getting out alive is never guaranteed.


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**Content Warnings:** *Final Light deals with fear, grief, death of loved ones, body horror, blood and gore, character death, and amputation. These are intrinsic themes of the game. Other themes may be related to certain characters and adventures you choose to play. Talk this out with your table and take care of each other.*

## WHAT YOU NEED TO PLAY

- A GM and 2–4 players
- Dice: 2d20, 4d4, 6d6
- One coin (heads/tails)
- Pencil and erasers for all
- *GM only:* the Local Anaesthetic scenario and the prep materials listed there (a separate download—no spoilers!)



# THE RHYTHM OF PLAY

In Final Light, players will cycle through sections of scavenging for supplies, escaping encounters, and stealing moments of relative safety to consider the monsters without and the monsters within.

As you tell this story together, there will be **narrative-driven** times where you act freely and tell the story together more loosely, using skill checks and items along the way to determine outcomes.

But sometimes you will arrive in a particular location that has story relevance or high danger (or both): this is called **an encounter**. Instead of "combat", your goal is to survive and escape while hopefully successfully doing whatever you were there to do. During encounters, you'll move across a map, use an action economy, and other game mechanics come into play. But even during encounters, while it can be tempting to turn on your board-game mind, you'll have a lot more fun if you remember the point of Final Light is to tell a good story together: do what your character would do, describe the moment cinematically, and let the mechanics carry your table's story into moments you never planned for.

# PERSONAL STAKES & CHARACTERS

Every character enters the story with a hidden burden or challenge—something out of their control that makes things harder. The GM assigns this secretly before play begins, and it includes a unique mechanical element that raises the stakes for that character and helps them jump into engaging character-driven play without having spent ten hours creating a backstory (no shade, we love this! It's just not required).

The Personal Stakes section of each character sheet is kept folded under and private. Players may share as much or as little as the story demands. They are the emotional core of each character, and the source of what allows a character to earn Light (see page 10).



# THE BASIC ROLL

When a character attempts something uncertain, the GM calls for a skill check: roll 1d20, add your Skill modifier (can be negative), and compare the total to the GM's target.

*Sneaking past infected, Stealth target 12. Roll 12+: you slip by. 11 or below: a glass smashes.*

## CRITICAL ROLLS

**Natural 20**: always a success, plus a bonus (extra info, a resource, Light, an enemy setback) or +1 damage for an attack roll.

**Natural 1**: automatic failure with a serious consequence (lose a resource, weapon breaks, attract attention, take 1 damage).

## ADVANTAGE & DISADVANTAGE

**Advantage:** Roll 2d20, use the higher result.

**Disadvantage:** Roll 2d20, use the lower one.

Multiple sources don't stack.

## GROUP CHECKS & HELPING

**Group checks:** Everyone rolls, and each person passes or fails on their own. A natural 20 also turns one other failure into a success; a natural 1 brings a consequence down on the whole group.

**Helping:** In an encounter, take the Help action to give an ally advantage on their next roll. Outside one, you both roll and the higher result counts, but a natural 1 from either of you hits you both.

# THE SKILLS

In this game you have seven base skills and two composite skills. The **seven base skills** are:

### Strength
*Using an axe, breaking away from an infected, pushing a vehicle*

### Precision
*Picking a manual lock, shooting a gun, throwing accurately*

### Awareness
*Spotting an ambush, finding hidden supplies, detecting lies*

### Persuasion
*Convincing someone to help, calming a panicked survivor, lying*

### Crafting
*Jury-rigging a barricade, creating items under pressure*

### Engineering
*Hot-wiring a vehicle, bypassing digital security, repairing a machine*

### Education
*Treating injuries, identifying chemicals, navigating by landmarks*

Modifiers typically range from −3 to +3.

There are **two composite skills** that are built by combining base skills:

### STEALTH
*Precision + Awareness + Persuasion*

### SCAVENGE
*Crafting + Engineering + Education*

When the GM calls for a check, you can propose which skill to use based on how you describe your approach. Creative solutions may lower difficulty or avoid the roll entirely.

You also have the option to expend an item from your inventory to **"succeed with an item"**. This is an auto-success. Explain how you're using that item to aid you (GM's ruling).

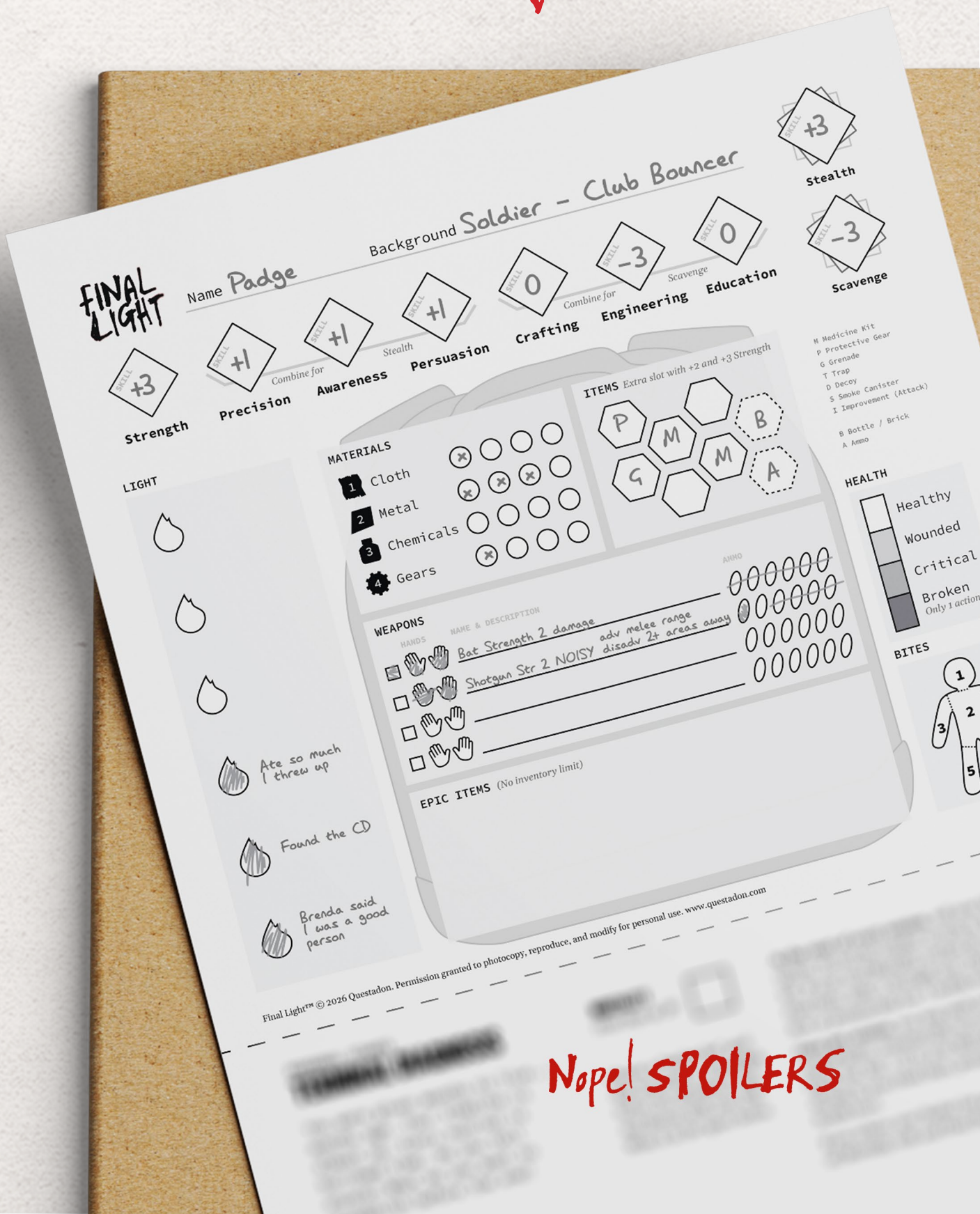
# CHARACTER SHEET PREP

**For this single-session scenario, character creation is slightly shortened.** Personal Stakes should be assigned privately before the session, and the GM should also let the player know what their background is, giving the players some time to think about how they might play the character.

When sitting down for this session, **pregenerated character sheets are provided**—players just write down the name of their character, and follow the GM's instructions to flesh out their character before beginning.

Here's a partially filled character sheet to reference.

*(The Personal Stakes section appears below the rest of the character sheet so it can be folded under—it's not shown here to avoid spoilers!)*



# HEALTH LEVELS

Instead of hit points, you have four Health Levels:

| LEVEL | EFFECT |
|---|---|
| Healthy | Full capability |
| Wounded | Hurt but functional |
| Critical | Seriously wounded (no mechanical penalty yet) |
| Broken | On death's door: only 1 action per turn in Encounters |

Each point of damage moves you down one level. Taking damage while Broken means death.

**Healing:** Med Kits restore 1 level (1 action to use).

*Note that most of your enemies will have relatively similar Health Levels to you (some weaker, some stronger). This is a game about humans and mutated humans—in the same way that getting stabbed one time would significantly injure you, in some cases might be all it takes to take down an infected.*

# SCAVENGING

As your player characters move through the world, you know to be on the lookout for things you can use—either useful items or materials you can use to make your own supply of things you might need.

To find these supplies, make a Scavenge Check. Roll 1d20 + your Scavenge modifier, plus 4d4. You can roll all five dice at once.

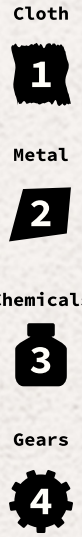
## ONE ITEM DIE

Your d20 is your item die (it determines if you find any ready-made items), and the d4s are your materials dice.

| ROLL (D20) | RESULT |
|---|---|
| Natural 20 | Find an Epic Item + choose 1 regular item |
| 20 or higher | Find an Epic Item |
| 10-19 | Choose 1 item (craftable or non-craftable) |
| 9 or lower | No item found (just your materials) |
| Natural 1 | No item OR MATERIALS found |

## FOUR MATERIAL DICE

Each d4 result gives one material.




*Preston makes a Scavenging check. He rolls a d20 and four d4s. He has a -2 Scavenge modifier, so his d20 roll of 13 gives him a total of 11: he will "find" a ready-made item of his choice (see Items tables on next page). He wants a smoke canister, but since materials he picked up will let him craft one, he chooses an Ammo as his item.*

*On his d4s, he gets a 2, two 3s, and a 4: he marks 1 metal, 2 chemicals, and 1 gear. He is in a safe area so he can craft right away: he uses the metal and one chemical to make a Smoke Canister and decides to save his gear and remaining chemical for later.*

You can scavenge freely in safe areas (just ask the GM where you want to look). In encounters, it requires an action.

Mark what you find in your inventory, minding the space you have available.

If you find an **Epic Item**, your GM will let you know what unique item (or weapon) you find. Epic Items do not require inventory space.

# CRAFTING

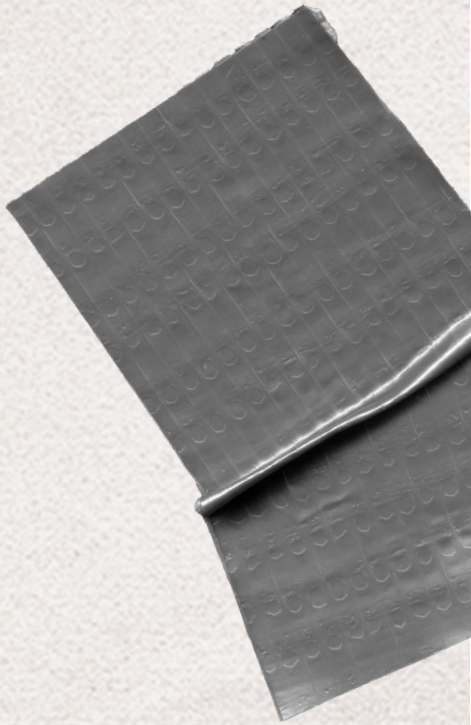
Craft items freely any time you're stationary and not in an encounter, no roll required. Crafting within an encounter costs 1 action. **Some items are craftable with materials, but some items can only be found.**

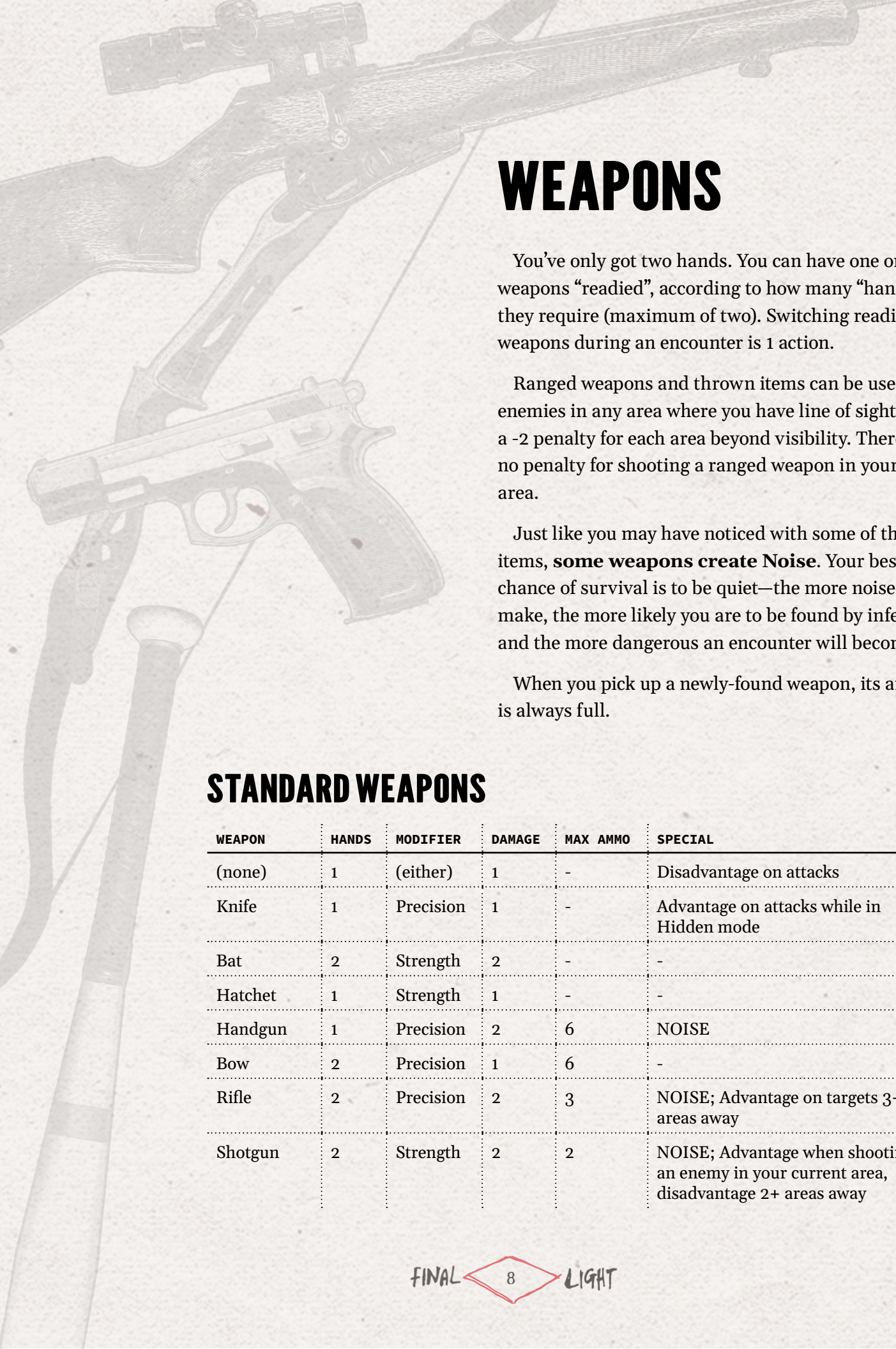
## ITEMS: CRAFTABLE

| ITEM | MATERIALS | EFFECT |
|---|---|---|
| Medicine Kit (M) | ■ + ● | Heals 1 Health Level (1 action) |
| Protective Gear (P) | ■ + ▰ | Absorbs 1 damage, then breaks (if in your inventory, can be used as a reaction). |
| Wind-Up Decoy (D) | ■ + ✹ | (1 action to set) Triggers in 2 rounds, making a loud **Noise**; draws enemies within 4 areas |
| Trap (T) | ▰ + ✹ | (1 action to set) Deals 1 damage to next creature entering area. |
| Smoke Canister (S) | ▰ + ● | (1 action to use) Fills target area with smoke by the end of your turn; area is Obscured for 2 rounds |
| Grenade (G) | ✹ + ● | (1 action) Thrown. All in target area take 1d4 damage. Makes **Noise**. |
| Weapon Improvement (I) | ■ + ▰ + ● + ✹ | (1 action to install) +5 to hit and +1 damage on next attack, then breaks. |

## ITEMS: NON-CRAFTABLE

| ITEM | EFFECT |
|---|---|
| Bottle / Brick (B) | Thrown; draw enemies in adjacent areas to target area; does NOT trigger Hunted mode |
| Ammo (A) | (1 action to use) Refill the bullets or arrows of one weapon |





# WEAPONS

You've only got two hands. You can have one or two weapons "readied", according to how many "hands" they require (maximum of two). Switching readied weapons during an encounter is 1 action.

Ranged weapons and thrown items can be used on enemies in any area where you have line of sight, with a -2 penalty for each area beyond visibility. There is no penalty for shooting a ranged weapon in your own area.

Just like you may have noticed with some of the items, **some weapons create Noise**. Your best chance of survival is to be quiet—the more noise you make, the more likely you are to be found by infected and the more dangerous an encounter will become.

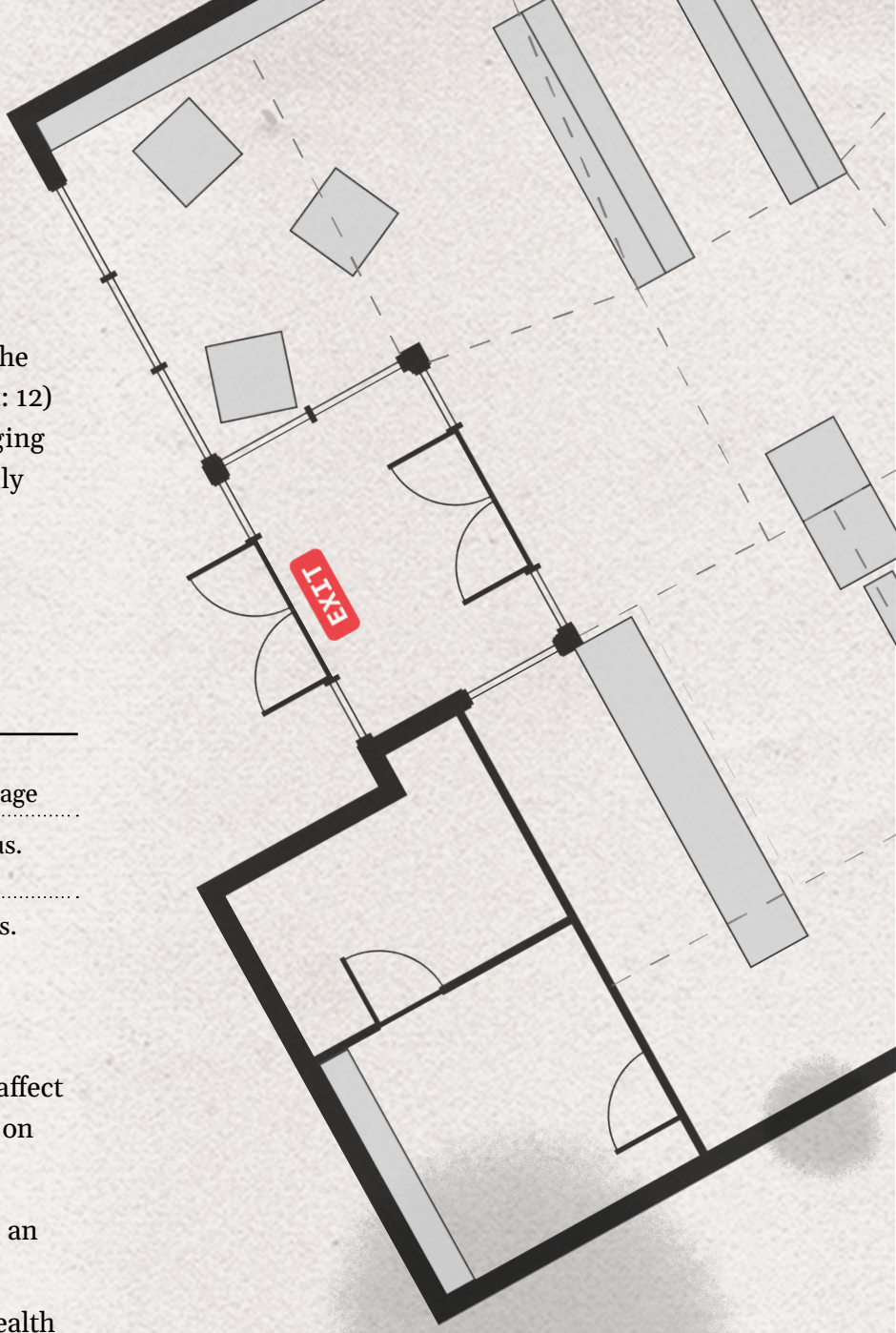
When you pick up a newly-found weapon, its ammo is always full.

## STANDARD WEAPONS

| WEAPON | HANDS | MODIFIER | DAMAGE | MAX AMMO | SPECIAL |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| (none) | 1 | (either) | 1 | - | Disadvantage on attacks |
| Knife | 1 | Precision | 1 | - | Advantage on attacks while in Hidden mode |
| Bat | 2 | Strength | 2 | - | - |
| Hatchet | 1 | Strength | 1 | - | - |
| Handgun | 1 | Precision | 2 | 6 | NOISE |
| Bow | 2 | Precision | 1 | 6 | - |
| Rifle | 2 | Precision | 2 | 3 | NOISE; Advantage on targets 3+ areas away |
| Shotgun | 2 | Strength | 2 | 2 | NOISE; Advantage when shooting an enemy in your current area, disadvantage 2+ areas away |

# STEALTH & VISIBILITY

Stealth is your best chance of survival. The GM calls for a Stealth check (default target: 12) when you're moving past enemies, scavenging in a dangerous area, or making a potentially noticeable sound.




## VISIBILITY

| LEVEL | EFFECT ON STEALTH |
|---|---|
| Clear | Line of sight limited only by walls/ furniture. Stealth rolls at disadvantage |
| Dim | Line of sight limited to 3-area radius. Vague motion beyond that |
| Dark | You can only see into adjacent areas. Stealth at advantage; Scavenge/ Awareness at disadvantage |

Note that some **Environmental Tags** affect stealth. Environmental tags can be placed on areas:

- Exit: an area where players can Escape an encounter.
- Cover (barrels, rubble, cars): grants Stealth advantage, and an enemy destroys the cover instead of dealing damage to you.
- Obscured (fog, smoke, rain): grants Stealth advantage but limits your own line of sight to adjacent areas.
- Hazard (fire, gas, debris): anyone moving through or remaining in this area takes 1 damage (sometimes avoided by a skill check success).

(Environmental Tags are explained more in the Core Book.)



# LIGHT

Light is the emotional resource at the heart of Final Light. You gain Light from meaningful moments—connection, kindness, bravery, an action that relates to your Personal Stakes—and spend it during critical moments to try to turn the tide.

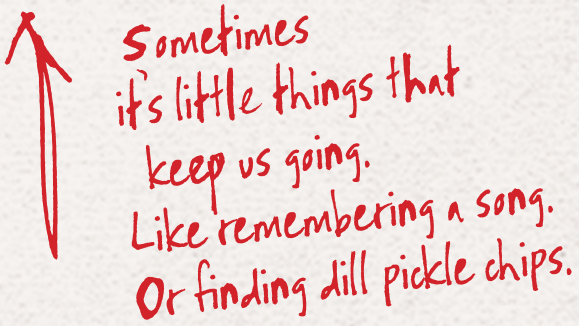
## EARNING LIGHT

When something happens in the story that gives your character hope, as a free action at any time, tell the table that you're marking Light and why. With the GM's confirmation, mark 1 Light and jot a couple words about the moment.

> *Cameron has just been attacked and is in Critical condition. On Jessica's turn, she says, "I'm going to use one action point to move here right next to Cameron, and I'm going to rip my protective gear off and shove it into his hands, between him and the infected." Jessica removes 1 protective gear from her inventory, and Cameron marks one in his.*
>
> *As Jessica indicates she's done her turn, Cameron says, "I think Cameron is kind of detaching and preparing for the end, but seeing Jessica do that, he steels himself and kind of gets his fight back. I think I'd gain Light from that."*
>
> *Everyone around the table nods, and the GM agrees: "Absolutely, mark it down." Cameron marks one Light and writes "Jessica protective gear" in the Light section on his sheet.*

There's an honour system with Light, which is why players need to say out loud if they intend to gain Light. If there's skepticism around the table because you can't really explain why this means something to your character, the GM will rule you don't get Light. The GM knows your character's personal stakes and has the final say.

The GM may also award Light at moments of emotional impact.





## SPENDING LIGHT

Light can be spent on your turn in an Encounter or during an important skill check. Declare what memory or hope is driving you, then spend ALL your accumulated Light (minimum 1) and roll that many d6s.

For each die you roll, an outcome occurs:

| D6 | EFFECT |
|---|---|
| 1-3 | **Inside an Encounter:** Add 1d6 to the Danger Pool—you're burning bright, drawing attention<br>**Outside an Encounter:** Lose an item from your inventory—you're focused on this moment and don't notice |
| 4-6 | *Choose one benefit (can choose same multiple times):*<br>Reroll a failed check,<br>Take 1 extra action, or<br>Grant an ally 1 extra action |

All Light is consumed regardless of outcome. Erase your notes. You're all-in.

## GIFTING LIGHT

Once per encounter, you may give 1 Light (no more) to another human who can hear or see you. Share how you're encouraging them. You retain all remaining Light, if you have more than one.

# ENCOUNTERS

Few places in the world are safe. When you move into an area where you will need to try to avoid/escape infected, you will enter an Encounter.

Encounters have two modes. They usually start in Hidden.

**HIDDEN:** Enemies unaware or uncertain of your presence. A group stealth check is made at the beginning of the round (Target 12), and each player narratively describes what they do that round. Move one area at a time towards your goal or the exit, making as little noise as possible. The GM narratively describes enemy and environment developments throughout the round as they occur.

**HUNTED:** Enemies know you're here, and will attempt to find and kill you until either you or they are eliminated.

**The encounter shifts to Hunted when** a group or ad hoc individual Stealth roll fails and the fiction demands it, a loud action is taken (gunfire, explosion, screaming, loud objects falling over), enemies visually confirm a survivor, or the GM decides the story merits it. Bricks and bottles do not trigger Hunted.

**The encounter ends when** all player characters have either escaped or been killed.

# HUNTED: HOW ROUNDS WORK

No initiative. Each round:

1. Every player takes one Spotlight Turn (2 actions each).
2. The GM takes one Enemy Escalation.
3. One d6 is added to the Danger Pool.

Enemy Escalation (GM chooses one of the following options per round):

- **Advance** — all enemies close distance toward nearest human
- **Attack** — all enemies within range attack
- **Trigger the Environment** — something changes (fire breaks out, structure shifts, the lights go out)

# PLAYER ACTIONS

| ACTION | EFFECT |
|---|---|
| Move | Move to an adjacent area (diagonal included) |
| Sprint | Move two areas, making 1 Noise |
| Attack | Roll d20 + Strength or Precision vs target difficulty |
| Use Item | Throw bottle, set trap, use med kit, etc. |
| Interact | Unlock a door, tamper with the environment, etc. |
| Change Weapon | Swap any/all of your weapons |
| Scavenge | Roll a Scavenge check and gather items & materials |
| Craft | Create an item from the materials in your backpack, DIY something, etc |
| Help | Grant an ally advantage on their next roll |
| Scan | Scan a bitten person to find out if they're infected |
| ESCAPE | Must be in an Exit area with no enemies present to take this action. If there are still no enemies present by the end of the round in which you took this action, you escape the encounter. |



# THE DANGER POOL

The longer you spend in an encounter, the more dangerous it becomes.

The Danger Pool holds dice equal to the number of players including the GM (e.g., 3 players + GM = 4 dice). The GM adds a d6 when:

- A round ends in Hunted mode
- Noise is made (gunfire, explosions, screaming)

## ROLLING THE DANGER POOL

When a die would be added but the pool is full, the GM immediately rolls all dice in the pool, and the dice determine what happens.

| NUMBER | EFFECT |
|---|---|
| 1 | Nothing happens! |
| 2 | Shrieker arrives |
| 3 | Runner arrives |
| 4 | Crusher arrives |
| 5-6 | Add 1 Evolved point |

After rolling, the pool is empty and will continue to refill. Usually, new infected arrive through an entrance, exit, or window.

## USING THE EVOLVED TRACK

The Evolved track starts empty. It has 4 slots.

**When the Evolved Track reaches 4 points,** an Evolved creature enters the encounter—a powerful extra-mutated infected with special and horrifying abilities.

**If an Evolved is already present** and the Evolved Track fills up again, its Mutation Ability triggers instead. If an Evolved has been defeated, the GM may choose to either take an enemy escalation or add 4 infected to play.

Reset the track to 0.

# INFECTED TYPES

Most infected mutated into one of three general types:

- Runners — the most human-looking; fast and particularly bitey
- Shriekers — elongated limbs and extremely perceptive; they sound the alarm when locating prey
- Crushers — encased and encrusted; slow to move but hard to kill

Infected do NOT roll to hit. They auto-hit any human in their area.

Their first attack will inflict 1 damage. Any subsequent hit while the human remains in the same area will be a Bite. Bites, if not blocked by some item or Cover, deal 1 damage and also mean there is a 50% chance that player is now infected.

Runners are fast, and they will ALWAYS bite.

Once an infected attacks a player, unless distracted away, they will focus on trying to infect or kill that player.

# BITES & INFECTION

There is a vaccine most survivors have received that gives a 50% chance of avoiding infection when bitten. When a human is bitten, follow these steps:

1. Roll 1d6 for bite location:

   1–2 = Head/Torso (Critical)
   3–4 = Arm (Non-Critical)
   5–6 = Leg (Non-Critical)

2. Flip a coin in secret (share result only with GM) to check infection.

   Heads = clean.
   Tails = infected.

3. If infected and bitten in a non-critical area, you may choose to amputate (you live, with a permanent penalty) or do nothing (you turn in 20 minutes). Critical bites cannot be amputated.

Amputation penalties:

- Arm = lose 1 hand (cannot use two-handed weapons)
- Leg = disadvantage on Stealth, can only Move one area per turn.

The character may tell the truth, lie, or say nothing about their infection status. No roll required to deceive unless they are pressed about it.

# CHARACTER DEATH

**When a character dies (or turns), ask the player to narrate their Light at the End.** In their last moment, what does your character see? A memory that brings them comfort, a face they picture, something they wish had been different?

Give this moment full focus before continuing.

When the moment allows, that player will re-enter the story as another character. The GM can decide whether the new character joins an in-progress encounter or arrives as the players escape.

**For this single-session scenario,** if the player character dies early in the game, the GM will provide another pre-generated character sheet to the player, otherwise… it's the end of the road.



# CONTINUING FORWARD

THIS IS ONE NIGHT. THE FULL GAME IS A JOURNEY.




This quick start gives just a taste of the full game. **Final Light** is built for 3–5 sessions, and the things that make it land need room to grow:

- Your characters' Personal Stakes lead to redemption or chaos,.. and possibly death.
- Moments filled with Light come back around in the moment you most need it.
- Your backpack fills, then empties, then fills again (and you adjust your strategy).

The **Core Book** includes the complete rules, an epic items compendium, a collection of Personal Stakes to start diverse character arcs, plus everything a GM needs to run the game and build their own adventures.

There are currently **four published adventures** for Final Light, available as separate zines at questadon.com.

Go tell some good stories.

We could all use a little Light these days.

Stay human.

x Sarah

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